

leading the party to a spectacular victory in the February 2005 assembly elections. Instead, Sonia Gandhi hand-picked Hooda for the top post.

Slighted, Lal went into a sulk-and-retreat mode while Bishnoi picked the gauntlet against the high command as the most vocal and vicious critic of Sonia Gandhi within the party. Though the AICC had suspended Bishnoi, the disciplinary action, far from mellowing him down, only sharpened his diatribe against an all-powerful party president and made him assiduously pursue his plan to float a new party.

Predictably, Hooda snidely dismissed his rivals' political venture as "a party of no consequence" taking comfort in the fact that Lal's elder son, Deputy Chief Minister Chander Mohan, and nephew, MLA Dura Ram, had stayed away from the Rohtak rally. But such a reaction could barely hide the concern in Congress quarters over Lal turning his back on the party given the sway he holds among non-Jat voters, who form more than two-thirds of the electorate. "Our party will be a potent alternative to Hooda and Chautala as the people of Haryana are fed up with both," said Bishnoi.

Hooda has, in fact, been unnerved by Bishnoi's political ascent as a rebel. It was his strident campaign against the transfer of 1,500 acres of government-acquired land to the Reliance Industries-led SEZ in the Gurgaon-Jhajjar area which has forced Hooda to revise the compensation policy. Bishnoi has been accusing Hooda and Sonia of favouring Reliance Industries and cheating the farmers of Haryana. In a damage control exercise, Hooda announced an additional compensation of Rs 30,000 per acre for the acquired land for 33 years to placate the discontent farmers.

Known as the master manipulator of Haryana politics, Lal has perfected the art of wooing MLAs and MPs in power games. In 1978, he led an unprecedented spectacle in Indian politics by ensuring an *en masse* defection of MLAs supporting Devi

Lal's rebellion has become a cause of concern for Hooda and the Congress given his sway over the non-Jat votebank



ANXIETY WRIT: The revolt could be bad news for Sonia and Hooda (left)

Lal to the Congress, toppling the government and becoming the chief minister himself. The episode had earned him the epithet of the "wholesale trader of MLAs". Lal again outwitted his opponent within the party in 1991, when he had the majority of MLAs supporting him for chief

ministership, virtually thumbing a nose at Rajiv Gandhi, who had favoured Lal's archrival Birender Singh. Lal's manipulative skills also came to the rescue of the Narasimha Rao government, when he played a major role in the defection of MPs from the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha.

By forming a new party without resigning from the elected positions they hold as Congressmen, both Lal and Bishnoi have cocked a snook at the high command which has so far dithered on expelling them from the party as such actions would have helped them retain their seats. "A legal action is underway to unseat the father-son rebels as they have forfeited their right to represent the Congress.", says an AICC functionary.

Apart from banking on his clean image, Bishnoi is counting on the growing public disaffection with the Hooda regime due to its lacklustre governance. Also, with Hooda's image dented by the incidents of anti-Dalit violence and the peasantry's disenchantment over the land acquisition, Bishnoi will be only waiting in the wings to shore up the third front in Haryana—probably the last political gambit of his father.